

A NATION'S SORROW
Women salvage belongings from the floodwaters in Sindh; below, Pakistan PM Shehbaz Sharif at a conference in Ankara, Turkey

FOCUSED ON HIS POLITICS, IMRAN INITIALLY SEEMED OBLIVIOUS TO THE PLIGHT OF FLOOD VICTIMS. SHEHBAZ ACQUITTED HIMSELF BETTER, TOURING FLOODED AREAS. HE ALSO RESTARTED THE IMF PROGRAMME

so as to get the IMF bailout programme back on track, were necessitated because Imran's government reneged on commitments to economic reform it had signed.

Some populist measures enacted by PTI at the fag end of its shortened tenure, such as freezing fuel and energy prices, were likened to "landmines laid by Imran Khan for the future government" by the current finance minister, Miftah Ismail. They led to an unsustainable strain on the economy, which not only led to the value of the Pakistan rupee plummeting and deficits climbing, but whose sudden reversals came as massive shocks to ordinary people.

Imran Khan's ostensible popular support has as much to do with the present coalition government expending its political capital to correct the distortions that he had himself introduced in Pakistan's economy. If the government were to, somehow, manage to rein in the galloping inflation in the coming months, there might be a completely different situation at the time of the general election, which is precisely why Imran has been crying for an immediate election.

Thirdly, Imran and the PTI have also been using unsubstantiated charges of a grand conspiracy—involving the US, the UK and the country's military—to whip up anti-western, anti-establishment sympathies among supporters. It's not clear how much further such emotions can be sustained, especially without any evidence, and how much of a dent they will make in the general election a year down the road, when voters' concerns will likely be different.

But perhaps more than anything else, Imran is himself battling some very serious charges that have the potential to get him disqualified from electoral politics. In fact, on more than one occasion, he and his party leaders have openly expressed the fear that there is a plan afoot to have him technically knocked out—implying that the country's military establishment is behind such machinations. The fact of the matter is, some of the charges have been around for over a decade and were only held in abeyance because of PTI's doggedness in delaying court hearings as well as the protection of the military, which helped usher Imran into power and protected him.

The most substantial of these cases relates to illegal